Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Job

Job 1:1

- The phrase "There once was a man" can begin a parable (symbolic story with asocial meanings) or a historical account (2 Samuel 12:1; 1 Samuel 25:2).
- Ezekiel 14:14, 20 and James 5:11 also mention Job.
- Uz is east of the Jordan River, either in Edom to the south or in Aram to the north (Genesis 36:28; 1 Chronicles 1:42; Jeremiah 25:19–20; Lamentations 4:21; Genesis 10:23; 22:21; 1 Chronicles 1:17, 42). Job was not from Israel. He lived before the nation of Israel existed and outside its later territory.
- Job had no moral faults, he was a man of complete integrity (Job 1:8; 2:3; see Psalms 25:21; 37:37; Proverbs 2:7; 20:11; 29:10). He did not claim to be perfect or without sin (Job 6:24; 7:21; see also Ecclesiastes 7:20; Romans 3:23; 1 John 1:8). But he was righteous (in a right relationship with God) so his suffering was not because of guilt. Here, fearing God probably means he did not worship any Ancient Near Eastern gods (see Psalms 111:10; Proverbs 1:7; 9:10; 2 Corinthians 7:1; Job 9:8; 23:13; 31:26–28).

Job 1:1–2:13

God and Satan agree to test Job, which causes his troubles and confirms his integrity (1:20–21; 2:10). None of the book's characters ever learn of this council in heaven.

Job 1:2–3

- God gave Job prosperity with many sons, daughters, cattle and other domestic animals, and servants (compare Genesis 30:43; Deuteronomy 7:13; Psalm 107:38).
- Numbers like seven and three (and 7,000 and 3,000) show the full extent of God's blessings for Job (see Job 42:13; also see Psalms 127:3–5; 128:3).
- Job was the greatest man of all the people of the East: The numbers describing Job's wealth might not be exact, but they are realistic for a wealthy man of that time (compare Nabal's wealth in 1 Samuel 25:2).

Job 1:5

- People often washed and changed clothes to purify themselves before making a sacrifice (Genesis 35:2; Exodus 19:10, 14).
- The usual time for sincere religious dedication was early morning (see Genesis 22:3; Psalm 5:3; Mark 1:35).
- cursed: The Hebrew verb barak (usually meaning blessed) used here is a polite way to say "cursed" (compare Job 1:11; 2:5, 9; 1 Kings 21:10, 13; Psalm 10:3). Job worried that his children might have committed this serious crime (Leviticus 24:10–16; 1 Kings 21:9–13; compare Job 1:11; 2:5, 9). Job knew that God regards wrong attitudes as sin (Jeremiah 17:9–10; Mark 7:21–23).

Job 1:6–7

- These sons of God are spiritual beings and members of the court of heaven. They are probably either holy angels or demons (Genesis 6:2, 4). They join God in his discussions, including during creation and in his rule over creation (Genesis 1:26; Job 1:6; Genesis 3:22; 2:1; 1 Kings 22:19–22; Psalms 82:1; 89:5, 7–8; Daniel 3:13, 17, 23, 25; 7:9–14).
- It is uncertain in the account if Satan usually came with other court members of heaven to report or if he forced his way in as Job's opponent.
- "Where have you come from?": This question was God's command for a report from one of his subjects (see Genesis 3:9).
- Satan was not roaming through the earth to do God's will (compare 1 Chronicles 21:1–14; 2 Kings 19:35 is equivalent to Isaiah 37:36; Ezekiel 1:5–9). Instead, he opposes God's plans (2 Timothy 2:26; 1 Peter 5:8).

Job 1:8

My servant:

People used this title for:

1. The patriarchs ("first fathers") of Israel (Genesis 26:24; Exodus 32:13).
2. The prophets (2 Kings 17:13; Jeremiah 7:25; Zechariah 1:6).
3. King David (for example, 2 Samuel 7:1–29; Psalms 18:1; 36:1).

Job 1:9–11

Job has a good reason (Hebrew khinnam; see study note on 2:3) to fear God. The wisdom tradition connects being religious with prosperity. Satan suggested that Job's dedication to God depended on his wealth.

Job 1:10

a hedge on every side: See 1 Samuel 25:16; Psalms 5:12; 34:7; Zechariah 2:5; compare Isaiah 5:5.

Job 1:11–12

- Stretch out ... and strike all he has ... Everything he has is in your hands: Satan was God's agent. The hand he used was both the Lord's and Satan's. They acted against everything Job owned and later against Job himself (2:5–6).
- Job later cursed the day of his birth, but he did not curse God (3:1, 8; 31:30). This was even true when his upset wife urged him to do so (2:9).
- God allowed Satan to test Job to show that Satan's negative view of Job was wrong (1 Corinthians 10:11; see James 1:13; compare Luke 22:31–32; John 19:11).

Job 1:13–19

- These attacks took away the blessings listed in 1:2–3. Job was left with four messengers who came to report terrible news and a wife who gave poor advice.
- The phrase "While he was still speaking" emphasizes the repeated nature of the attacks (see Jeremiah 51:31). The phrase "I alone have escaped to tell you" emphasizes the complete destruction of Job's resources.

Job 1:15

The Sabeans were tribes who raided from the desert (compare Judges 6:3). By the 700s BC, the southern Sabeans became a powerful nation. They traded in gold, precious stones, sweet smelling liquids, and slaves (see Psalm 72:10; Isaiah 43:3; 45:14; 60:6; Jeremiah 6:20).

Job 1:16

The fire of God ... from heaven: This might have been lightning, fire in the desert, or the activity of a volcano (20:26; Leviticus 10:2; 1 Kings 18:38; 2 Kings 1:10–14; Numbers 11:1–3; Genesis 19:24).

Job 1:19

a mighty wind ...struck the four corners of the house: This suggests that Job and his children were farmers settled and living in houses, not people wandering about and living in tents (nomads).

Job 1:20

- Job stood up, tore his robe, and shaved his head: These were common ceremonies in the Ancient Near East to show grief. People sometimes responded this way instead of harming themselves when shocked, in horror, or after hearing bad news (2:12; Genesis 37:29, 34; Judges 11:35; Jeremiah 16:6; Ezekiel 7:18; Amos 8:10).
- He fell to the ground and worshiped: Then in an unexpected move, Job did not give a desperate cry, but had hope (1 Peter 5:6).

Job 2:1–3

This scene repeats exactly as it did in 1:6–8.

Job 2:3

The phrase without cause (Hebrew khinnam) is a play on words from Satan's question in 1:9.

Job 2:5

strike his flesh and bones: People once believed bones were the source of health.

Job 2:6

spare (literally guard or watch over): Ironically, God made Satan responsible for guarding Job's life (compare 10:13–14; 13:27; 33:11).

Job 2:7

This Hebrew term for terrible boils referred to any raised wounds that leak (Exodus 9:10; Leviticus 13:18–20; Deuteronomy 28:27, 35).

Job 2:8

- Job might have scraped his skin for relief. The ancient Greek Old Testament (Septuagint) says it was "to scrape away the pus."
- The ashes might refer to a place where they placed lepers in isolation. But Job was probably showing his grief and how desperate he was (30:19; Genesis 18:27; 2 Samuel 13:19; Isaiah 58:5; Jonah 3:6).

Job 2:9

Job's wife first summarized Job's temptation by echoing God's words. Job was trying to "retain his integrity" (2:3). In her frustration and pain, she then advised Job to curse God. Without knowing it, she was asking Job to fulfill Satan's prediction (1:11; 2:5).

Job 2:10

- Job accepted both good and bad things from God, showing his right relationship and faith in God (righteousness) (compare 1:21; 2 Samuel 12:16–20; Luke 22:42).
- By saying nothing wrong, Job controlled his tongue (Proverbs 13:3; 21:23; see James 3:2).

Job 2:11

- It might have taken several months for Job's three friends to learn about his troubles (see study note on 6:14–27; see 7:3).
- The text suggests that Job's three friends were Edomites, a people known for their wisdom (Jeremiah 49:7; Obadiah 1:8).
- Eliphaz the Temanite was probably a descendant of Esau's grandson Teman (Genesis 36:10–11, 15). His land was in Edom (Ezekiel 25:13; Amos 1:11–12).
- The "Bil-" part of the name "Bildad" would remind Hebrew readers of names like Bilhan, a descendant of Esau (Genesis 36:27; 1 Chronicles 1:42). The "-dad" part of the name would remind readers of names like Bedad, father of the Edomite king Hadad (Genesis 36:35; 1 Chronicles 1:46).
- Shuhite: No place named "Shuah" is known, but Abraham's son "Shuah" was sent to "a land in the east" (Genesis 25:1, 6; 1 Chronicles 1:32).
- The ancient Greek Old Testament (Septuagint) lists Zophar instead of "Zepho" as one of Esau's grandsons (Genesis 36:11, 15; 1 Chronicles 1:36). A Naamathite might live in a town named "Naamah." But no such place is known. Two Old Testament women are named "Naamah," but neither is likely an ancestor of Zophar (Genesis 4:22; 1 Kings 14:21).

Job 2:12

- They could barely recognize Job: This expression shows how much Job had suffered (compare Isaiah 52:14; 53:3).
- Job's friends showed their grief and began to weep aloud, as if Job was dead.
- Throwing dust sometimes showed anger or hate (see 2 Samuel 16:13; Acts 22:23). But here it showed grief (see Joshua 7:6; 1 Samuel 4:12; Nehemiah 9:1; Lamentations 2:10).

Job 2:13

- Job's friends sat on the ground to share in Job's suffering (see 2:8).
- People usually showed grief for seven days and nights when an important person died or to acknowledge other bad news (Genesis 50:10; 1 Samuel 31:13; see also Ezekiel 3:14–15).

Job 3:1–10

- Job spoke and risked words of sin (1:21; 2:10).
- Job cursed the day of his birth in great detail. However, his words sounded more like sad complaints. Job did not curse God as his creator, but he showed grief about the condition of his life.

Job 3:1–26

Job's outbreak of emotion did not mean his integrity failed under pressure (42:7–8; James 5:11). The prophets Elijah and Jeremiah, both men of God, exaggerated with similar language (1 Kings 19:4; Jeremiah 20:14–18).

Job 3:5

Job wished that the darkness of the place of the dead and the gloom of death had not allowed him to be born (Exodus 10:22; Proverbs 4:19; Joel 2:2; Job 10:21–22; 38:17).

Job 3:8

The phrase those who curse the day refers to people paid to curse, like Balaam (Numbers 22–24).

Job 3:9

Venus and Mercury, known as the morning stars, announce the arrival of dawn (38:7).

Job 3:10

shut the doors of the womb: Closing or opening the womb can mean conception (Genesis 16:2; 20:18; 29:31; 30:22; 1 Samuel 1:5–6). But here it means birth (see also Job 38:8).

Job 3:11–24

Job's language shifts from wishing he was never born to grief. He goes from hating life towards an attraction for death. Job asks "why" seven times, as he has grief for his situation (3:11, 12, 16, 20, 23; see Psalms 10:1; 22:1; Jeremiah 20:18; Lamentations 5:20).

Job 3:14

People believed the dead kept their identities and social status. Job might have wanted kings and prime ministers to recognize his status as a prince (1:3).

Job 3:15

who had gold, who filled their houses with silver: This might refer to tombs filled with treasure. However, it more likely refers to the useless storing of wealth that ends in death (as in 3:14).

Job 3:20

- Job compared light to life (33:30; see John 1:4; 8:12).
- Bitter might mean:

1. "Angry" (Judges 18:25).
2. "Fierce" (2 Samuel 17:8).

3. “Anguish” (Job 7:11).
4. Desperate (Proverbs 31:6).
5. “Distress” (1 Samuel 1:10; 22:2).

Job 3:21

People in grief desperately long for death, like those who search for hidden treasure.

Job 4:1–2

- Eliphaz the Temanite was probably the oldest and most important of Job’s friends (see study note on 2:11). His speeches are longer and more detailed than the others.
- who can keep from speaking?: Eliphaz imitated how urgent a message from prophets can be (4:12–16; see Jeremiah 20:9; Amos 3:8).

Job 4:1–14.22

This section starts three rounds of speeches by Job’s three “comforters,” each followed by Job’s response (4:1–27:23). In the first round, Job’s friends urge him to seek God to regain prosperity.

Job 4:3–4

These were people who were weak, felt depressed, and had low confidence in themselves (Isaiah 13:7; 35:3; Ezekiel 7:17).

Job 4:7

Job probably considered his children among the innocent who died (1:5). Even Eliphaz must have known that people sometimes “shed innocent blood” (compare Deuteronomy 19:10; Proverbs 6:17; Jeremiah 7:6).

Job 4:8

The symbolic use of the language of harvest shows the idea in the Scriptures that actions deserve judgment (Proverbs 22:8; Hosea 8:7; Romans 2:9–11; Galatians 6:7–8). The New Testament compares the final judgment to a harvest (Matthew 13:39). By this principle, Jesus rejected overly simple attempts to analyze people’s lives (Luke 13:4; John 9:1–3).

Job 4:9

by the blast of His anger they are consumed: Eliphaz saw the wind in 1:19 as God’s judgment (compare Isaiah 40:7; Hosea 13:15).

Job 4:12–16

Eliphaz claimed to be a prophet, suggesting that God spoke to him secretly (Numbers 12:6). Later, God did speak to him, but not to support his advice (Job 42:7).

Job 4:13

Eliphaz probably referred to the sleep caused by God that links to the visions given to prophets (33:15; Genesis 15:12; Numbers 12:6; Isaiah 29:10).

Job 4:14

- Fear often occurs in God’s presence (Genesis 15:12; Daniel 8:17–18; 10:8–10). But God tells his people not to fear (Genesis 15:1; 26:24; Isaiah 40:9; 44:8).
- Eliphaz’s bones shook like those of a prophet with terrible news to share (Jeremiah 23:9; Habakkuk 3:16).

Job 4:15

a spirit (or wind) glided past my face: Wind shows God’s powerful presence in a physical way (38:1; Nahum 1:3; Acts 2:2; compare 1 Kings 19:11).

Job 4:17

The characters in the book often say that no one is truly righteous or pure (see 9:2; 15:14; 25:4; 35:7). This is because everyone is flawed (Psalms 14:3; 53:3; Romans 3:10–11). Eliphaz used these terms to say that humans are full of sin and God has no sin. Job and God used them to show that Job had fulfilled his duties to God. Job and Eliphaz never agreed on what these terms meant. Later, God said that Eliphaz had not spoken about him “accurately” (Job 42:7).

Job 4:18–21

The idea that God does not trust His servants and charges His angels with error is unique (but see Genesis 6:1–4).

Job 4:21

A tent often symbolized human life (Isaiah 38:12; 2 Corinthians 5:1; compare Ecclesiastes 12:6).

Job 5:1

The holy ones probably refers back to the angels mentioned in 4:18. They are “holy ones” because of they are close to God, not because they have achieved moral perfection (15:15; Daniel 4:14; 8:13; Zechariah 14:5).

Job 5:4

in court: Literally this reads, in the gate. At that time, legal and business discussions happened. Job participated in these discussions (29:7; see Deuteronomy 21:19–21; Ruth 4:1–11).

Job 5:8

- Appeal to God: This meant a formal request for help, advice, or removal of blame, sometimes through asking God to forgive (Amos 5:4, 6). It could possibly refer to an appeal through a message from a prophet (Genesis 25:22; 1 Samuel 9:9; 1 Kings 22:8).
- Job wanted to present his cause before God. Later he tried to do that very thing (Job 13:3, 15, 18; 23:3–8; 29:1–31:40).

Job 5:9–10

The region where Job lived relied on rain instead of human methods to water crops (see 36:27–28).

Job 5:9–16

Eliphaz praised God as the creator and and the one who sustains the universe who performs wonders (5:9–10). He also praised God as the righteous judge who humbles the powerful and honors poor people (5:11–16).

Job 5:13

God catches the wise in their craftiness (Proverbs 12:13). The apostle Paul referred to this idea when he rejected the wisdom of the world (1 Corinthians 1:19).

Job 5:17

the discipline of the Almighty: See Deuteronomy 8:5; Proverbs 3:11–12; Revelation 3:19.

Job 5:19–26

- Six calamities ... in seven: This formula for wise sayings suggests a condition of completion (compare Proverbs 30:15–31).
- This list reflects the blessings and curses of the covenant God gave to Moses (Leviticus 26; Deuteronomy 28).

Eliphaz believed that people in a right relationship with God would avoid:

1. Famine, meaning starving. (Job 5:20, 22; see Leviticus 26:4–5, 10; Deuteronomy 28:4–6, 8, 11–12).
2. Battle and its destruction (Job 5:20; 5:21, 22; see Leviticus 26:6–8; Deuteronomy 28:7, 48).
3. Scourge of the tongue, or words spoken against them (slander).
4. They would even be at peace with wild animals and the stones of the field (Job 5:23; see Leviticus 26:6). This peace might mean productive fields instead of rocky ones (2 Kings 3:19, 25; Matthew 13:5). Or it might symbolize broader harmony with creation (see Psalm 91:11–12).

Job 5:24

nothing amiss: See Deuteronomy 28:11–12; compare with Job 1:6–19.

Job 5:25

descendants like the grass of the earth: See Genesis 22:17; Leviticus 26:9; Deuteronomy 28:4, 11–12.

Job 6:1–7.21

Job responds by criticizing his counselors and questioning God (chapters 6 and 7). He explains his intense words by indicating his deep “grief” or “anguish” (6:2–3; 7:11). Job states that Eliphaz has not provided comfort or sympathy as a friend. Instead, Eliphaz chose to argue about out of date religious or theological ideas.

Job 6:3–4

In the Old Testament, arrows symbolize danger, disease, and destruction from God (7:20; 16:12–13; Deuteronomy 32:23–24, 42; Psalms 7:12–13; 38:2; 64:7; 91:5–6; Lamentations 2:4; 3:12–13; Ezekiel 5:16).

Job 6:6

The tasteless food ... the white of an egg? Job’s complaint in the form of a word puzzle (riddle) probably refers to both Eliphaz’s weak advice and the situation God allowed him to endure that Job hates.

Job 6:9

At one time, both the prophets Moses and Elijah asked God to end their lives (Numbers 11:15; 1 Kings 19:4).

Job 6:14–27

Job and his friends might have shared a covenant (special agreement) of loyalty and faith (Hebrew khesed; see Genesis 21:23; Exodus 15:13; 1 Chronicles 16:34). This bond would have made them like brothers, those who protect, and friends he could trust (Job 6:14–15; 6:21–23, 27). If they were in a covenant with one another, Job was accusing his friends of violating their covenant with him.

Job 6:19

- The city of Tema, located in the northern Arabian desert, was at the place roads crossed from Damascus to Mecca and from the Persian Gulf to Aqaba (Isaiah 21:14; Jeremiah 25:23). They might have named it after an ancestor who descended from Ishmael (Genesis 25:15). It was different from "Teman," which was Eliphaz's home in Edom.
- Sheba, situated in southwest Arabia, was a trading city for valuable goods (Psalm 72:10, 15; Isaiah 60:6; Jeremiah 6:20; Ezekiel 27:22–23; 38:13).

Job 6:27

even cast lots for an orphan: Job once protected orphans (31:17, 21). He used a common saying to show his counselors' lack of compassion for those who had no one to defend them (see 17:5).

Job 6:30

Can my mouth not discern malice?: Job might have been referring to his earlier comment about a "tasteless" and unpleasant diet (6:6–7).

Job 7:1

Human life has been difficult since the effects of the first human sin (Genesis 3:17; 5:29; Ecclesiastes 1:2, 13–14; 2:11, 17; Romans 8:20–22).

Job 7:2

Employers had the obligation to pay workers at the end of each day (Leviticus 19:13; Deuteronomy 24:15). But this did not always happen (Jeremiah 22:13; Malachi 3:5; James 5:4).

Job 7:3

- Job's testing might have lasted for months.
- The Hebrew word ('amal) appears throughout Job and means "misery" or "miserable" or "trouble" (3:20; 11:16; 16:2; 20:22; 3:10; 4:8; 5:6, 7; 15:35).

Job 7:5

Job's mention of worms symbolized the human fate of death and the widespread corruption in Sheol (25:6; 17:14; 21:26; 24:20; see Isaiah 14:11).

Job 7:6–21

Job cried out to God, saying life was too short (7:6–10). This complaint contrasts with his earlier wish for God to end his life (6:9).

Job 7:7

- People who ask God to remember usually seek his promised mercy (Psalms 35:6; 106:4).
- Job's statement that life is but a breath (Hebrew ruakh) meant he was either close to death or that life is like the passing of the wind (Psalm 39:9, 11).

Job 7:8

You will look for me, but I will be no more: The ancient Greek Old Testament (Septuagint) left out this verse. They did not want to suggest that God could not see Job in Sheol (see study note on 7:9).

Job 7:9

goes down to Sheol: This is the first plain mention of Sheol in Job.

It is described as:

1. A place of rest from the pressures and distinctions of earth (3:13–19).
2. "Darkness" (10:21–22; 17:13).
3. Deep in the earth (11:8).
4. Covered in dust (17:16).
5. The fate of all living beings from which no one can return (30:23; 10:21; see Genesis 37:25; 2 Samuel 12:12).

Job 7:11

I will not restrain my mouth: Job echoed Eliphaz's struggle to "keep from speaking" (4:2).

Job 7:12

The sea (Hebrew yam) and the monster (Hebrew tannin) symbolize chaos opposing God's order of creation. In Canaanite mythology, "Yam" was the original sea god, and "Tannin" was a sea monster or a god of the myth of chaos (Jeremiah 51:34; Psalm 74:13–14). This chaos also appears in Job as "Leviathan" or "Rahab" (Job 3:8; Isaiah 27:1; Job 9:13; 26:12; Isaiah 51:9). The Lord has total control (sovereignty) over the sea and everything it represents (Job 26:12; 38:8–11; Psalm 89:9–10; Jeremiah 5:22).

Job 7:13–14

Job's dreams and visions while sick were similar to those of Eliphaz (4:12–16).

Job 7:16

for my days are but a breath: Literally for my days are a vapor (Hebrew hebel); see the Theme Note titled "All Is 'Vapor'."

Job 7:17–18

- that You should exalt him: Compare with Psalm 8:4–5, which expresses similar thoughts in a positive way.
- attend (Hebrew paqad): In Psalm 8:4, this term means "to honor or care for." Job used it ironically to mean "You bother yourself" (compare with "punished," Isaiah 26:14).

Job 7:19

- Will You never look away from me (literally How long will you not look away from me): Job wanted the opposite of the attention that loyal people usually desire (Numbers 6:25; Psalms 27:9; 69:17; 80:3, 7, 19; Lamentations 1:9).
- to swallow: This means "a chance to calm my breathing."

Job 7:20

- Watcher of mankind: Instead of praising God for his goodness shown in careful attention, Job accused God of hostile surveillance. This actually describes Satan's actions (Deuteronomy 32:10; Psalm 25:21; Proverbs 24:12; Job 1:7).
- Why comes from the language of grief (see study note on 3:11–24).
- Your target: See 6:4; Lamentations 3:12.

Job 8:1

Like Eliphaz, Bildad the Shuhite thought Job's suffering was God's punishment (see study note on 2:11; 8:3–6, 13; compare 4:7–8; 5:2–3). Bildad respected the wisdom of the past and spoke to Job with both advice and encouragement (8:8–10; compare 4:7; 8:3–6, 8–10; compare 4:12–21; 5:9–16; 8:5–7, 20–22; compare 4:6; 5:19–26). He suggested that Job should stop complaining. Bildad advised Job to "ask the Almighty for mercy" and let God's justice restore him (8:1–7).

Job 8:2

How long: Bildad might have meant make fun of Job using a similar question (see 7:19).

Job 8:3–4

Bildad believed God does not pervert justice. He thought the death of Job's children showed they had sinned against God. Bildad divided people into "the blameless" (Hebrew tam, 8:20a; see 1:1) or "the godless" (Hebrew khanep, 8:13b). He believed one could distinguish them by observing God's actions toward them.

Job 8:7

your latter days will flourish: Bildad's words were more accurate than he realized (42:12; compare 5:19–26).

Job 8:8–10

Bildad argued for traditional wisdom by referring to ancient traditions and history (Deuteronomy 4:32; Jeremiah 18:13).

Job 8:9

born yesterday and know nothing: Bildad suggested that Job's generation was either born too late to know ancient wisdom or too young to have gathered it.

Job 8:11

Papyrus reeds can grow as high as three to four and one-half meters (ten to fifteen feet).

Job 8:12–13

To forget God means behaving as if God does not exist or cannot see (see Psalms 10:4; 14:1; Zephaniah 1:12; see Job 22:13–17; Psalm 94:7).

Job 8:16–17

In this symbolic story, a plant spreads its shoots over the garden. The roots wrap around the rock heap, giving the plant stability.

Job 9:1–35

Job answered Bildad by describing God's universal and legal power. His speech resembles a complex legal case.

It includes:

1. A summons and response (9:3, 14–16, 19b, 32).
2. The risk of proving himself guilty (9:20).
3. A "mediator" (9:33–34).
4. A question of accusation (9:12).
5. A legal sentence (9:22).
6. A declaration of guilt (9:28–30).

Job 9:3

If one wished to contend with God: Job later wished to meet God in court (13:3, 15, 23; 23:4).

Job 9:5–6

When God moves mountains or shakes the earth, it shows his presence as:

- One who gives laws (Exodus 19:18).
- One who judges (Jeremiah 4:24).
- One who rescues (Psalm 18:7; Isaiah 13:13; 29:6).

Job 9:9

- Job 38:32 mentions the Bear. It is often identified as "Arcturus." It might also refer to the constellations (star patterns) "Ursa Minor" or "Leo."
- the Pleiades is a group of seven stars, referenced at 38:31 and Amos 5:8.

Job 9:13

the helpers of Rahab: Job described the power of demons as mythical sea monsters that represented chaos. This kind of imagery appears in other parts of the Bible as well (26:12; Psalm 89:11; Isaiah 51:9).

Job 9:17

with a tempest: The words translated as "with a tempest" (bis'arah) might also mean besa'arah ("for a hair," meaning "for the smallest thing"). This would parallel "without cause."

Job 9:21

Job was truly blameless, and he consistently claimed this during the debate (1:1, 7; 2:3; 23:11–12; 27:5; 31:1–40).

Job 9:28

The word "You" shows this is a prayer, even though, "O God," is not plainly stated in Hebrew.

Job 9:30

wash myself: Job talked about using the strongest soap (lye) to represent removing all sin (1:5; compare Psalm 26:6; Matthew 27:24).

Job 9:31

- The pit can refer to the place of dead people, suggesting the "corruption" of death (17:14; 33:18).
- The dirty clothes representing being guilty contrast with the clean clothes representing being innocent (Zechariah 3:3–5; see Isaiah 61:10; 64:6; Revelation 19:8).

Job 9:32–33

A mediator does not judge God and man. Instead, the mediator helps bring them together (see 16:19–21).

Job 10:8–11

- A series of images shows God's role in creating Job.
- Your hands shaped me ... You molded me like clay: This is how a "potter" makes a vessel (Isaiah 45:9; Jeremiah 18:1–12). Although the potter has complete control over the clay, Job still questioned God (Isaiah 45:9; Jeremiah 18:5–12; Romans 9:20–25).
- return me to dust: This common theme in Job shows life's temporary nature (Job 4:19; 7:9–10, 21; 14:1–2, 10; see Genesis 3:19).
- You not pour me out like milk, and curdle me like cheese: The Hebrew terms create a lively image of a new born baby still covered with vernix (a creamy substance).

Job 10:20–22

Earlier, Job described "Sheol" as a somewhat peaceful place (3:13–19). Now, he calls it a land of darkness and gloom (see also 7:9–10; 14:7–22).

Job 11:1

Zophar the Naamathite, the most harsh of Job's three friends, focused only on the issue of sin (see study note on 2:11).

Job 11:2–3

- This stream of words: Those who are foolish and those who sin often talk too much, but Job was innocent (Proverbs 10:8, 14; Proverbs 10:19).
- Will you scoff without rebuke?: Zophar thought Job's comments were full of sin because he was making fun of God's justice (Job 10:2–7, 13–15).

Job 11:4

My doctrine is sound: Job was not defining doctrine but was defending his own integrity.

Job 11:5–6

exacts from you less than your iniquity deserves: Zophar believed that disasters were God's punishment for sins (compare 34:36).

Job 11:7

discover the limits of the Almighty: No one can fully understand the Almighty, who is beyond the heavens, the place of dead people, the land, and the sea (11:8–9).

Job 11:13–14

Zophar outlined three conditions for restoration (11:15):

1. Direct your heart. This is an internal action beyond mere ceremony.
2. Lift up your hands. This is a symbolic gesture of prayer, appeal, or act of surrendering (Exodus 9:29; Proverbs 1:24; Isaiah 1:15).
3. Put away the iniquity. This is not through sacrifice and regret, but by quitting the sin in view (compare Hebrews 11:6; James 4:8; 5:16).

Job 12:1–14.22

In his longest speech so far, Job responds to Zophar's comments and the entire first round of speeches.

Job 12:7–8

ask the animals ... the birds ... the earth ... the fish: Job believed the reason for his grief was obvious and that even creation would understand it (Proverbs 6:6). Later, God directed Job to the animal kingdom to show him that he did not understand (Job 38–40).

Job 12:7–9

The change from you (plural in 12:2–3) to you (singular here) probably indicates that Job is speaking to Zophar.

Job 12:9

the hand of the LORD: This is the only place in the dialogues where the Hebrew name, "Yahweh" ("the LORD"), appears (chapters 3–27; 29–37). For Job, the issue was not who caused his grief but why it happened.

Job 12:11

the tongue tastes its food: See 6:6–7.

Job 12:12

Wisdom is found with the elderly: People often think wisdom comes with old age. Job's friends supported this idea but Job doubted it (8:8–10; 15:10; 32:6–9; 12:20).

Job 12:17

He leads counselors away barefoot: In this metaphor, God removes leaders' abilities. It could also mean losing the symbols of office or becoming naked captives (12:18–19).

Job 12:18

When God removes the royal robe of kings, he takes away their symbols of authority (compare 19:9). It can also mean "God loosens the bonds of kings," referring to the control they have imposed on others.

Job 12:19

The priests lose their status or their priestly robes. They might even be naked captives (12:18).

Job 12:21

- Pours out contempt on nobles: Compare Psalm 107:40.
- disarms the mighty (literally loosens the belt of): The strong are not ready for battle anymore.

Job 12:22

- He reveals the deep things: This phrase might refer to Zophar's words that God's knowledge is "deeper than Sheol" (11:8).
- darkness ... deep shadows: The Old Testament often describes God as living in darkness and showing himself through darkness (1 Kings 8:12; 2 Chronicles 6:1; 2 Samuel 22:10, 12; Psalm 18:9, 11). Examples are when he gave the law at Sinai or when he comes in judgment (Deuteronomy 4:11; 5:22–23; Zephaniah 1:15).

Job 12:23–24

- Compare Daniel 2:21.
- He deprives the earth's leaders of reason: See Job 12:18; compare Daniel 4:23, 32–33.
- He... makes them wander in a trackless wasteland: This is like the "nobles" in Psalm 107:40 (see Job 12:21).

Job 12:25

Lack of wise advice might have caused the kings to stagger like drunkards (12:17; see Isaiah 19:14). This happened because they experienced God's punishment (Psalm 75:8; Jeremiah 25:15–27).

Job 13:1–2

Job appealed to experience, just like his comforters had done (3:12–17; 5:2).

Job 13:7–10

Will you speak wickedly on God's behalf: False witnesses were not allowed, even when speaking for God (Exodus 20:16).

Job 13:12

Ashes have no value (see Isaiah 44:20).

Job 13:20–21

Job thought about finding a judge to remove God's burden from him (9:33–34). Eliphaz had encouraged Job to accept God's discipline (5:17).

Job 13:22–23

Job wanted God to call or summon him, so Job could defend himself. Or as an alternative, Job would speak to God. Then God would respond with the charges against Job. Since God did not choose the first option,

Job started the second one (13:23). Eventually, God did call Job (38:1–3; 40:1–2). But Job could not reply (40:3–5).

Job 13:24

- God can turn away in "anger"(Deuteronomy 31:18; Isaiah 54:8; Jeremiah 33:5). Or he can choose not to show friendship (Psalms 30:7; 69:17; 102:2).
- Job, perhaps making a play of words on his own name (ʾiyyob), denied being God's enemy (ʾoyeb).

Job 13:25

In the Old Testament, dry chaff often symbolizes something that can blow away or burn (Psalm 83:13; Isaiah 40:24; Jeremiah 13:24; Exodus 15:7; Isaiah 47:14; Malachi 4:1; see also "dry grass," Isaiah 5:24; 33:11). It also represents weakness and lack of importance (Job 41:20–21; Isaiah 41:2).

Job 14:1–2

- The flower symbolizes how short life is (Psalms 90:5–6; 103:15–16; Isaiah 40:6–7).
- A shadow passes quickly (1 Chronicles 29:15; Psalm 102:11).

Job 14:3

open Your eyes: Job complained about God's constant surveillance (7:8, 17–20; 10:6, 14; 13:27).

Job 14:12

does not rise: Job did not have even the minimal evidence of resurrection found in the Old Testament (2 Kings 13:21; Isaiah 26:19; Daniel 12:2; see also Job 19:25). Job was not focusing on the end of the universe when the heavens will disappear (Psalm 102:25–26; Isaiah 34:4; 51:6; Hebrews 1:10–12). He was referring to the eternal nature of the heavens (Psalm 148:6; see also Psalms 72:5, 7, 17; 89:29, 37). His phrase refers to the permanent state of death.

Job 14:13

The grave is a permanent home (14:10–12, see 3:13–19; 7:6–10; 10:20–22). Job could not fulfill his request from 13:20–21 to hide temporarily in the grave.

Job 14:16

count my steps: Here, Job refers to God's protective care rather than his surveillance (10:12; 13:27; 14:3).

Job 14:17

If transgression becomes sealed in a bag, it does not wait for judgment (Deuteronomy 32:34–35; Hosea 13:12). It remains hidden forever. Job was asking for God to forgive him.

Job 14:22

Job no longer considered Sheol as a safe place (3:17–19; 14:13–17). The Old Testament often describes dead people as having no feelings (Psalm 88:12; Ecclesiastes 9:5; compare Isaiah 50:11; 66:24). The New Testament more plainly teaches that evil dead people experience suffering (Luke 16:23, 28; Revelation 14:11).

Job 15:1–21.34

In this second round of speeches, Job's friends discuss the fate of wicked people. They suggest that Job's condition means he has sinned.

Job 15:2–3

fill his belly with the hot east wind: The east wind was hot, so it might symbolize upset or violent speech (Exodus 14:21; Hosea 13:15; Jonah 4:8; Job 27:21; Jeremiah 18:17).

Job 15:6

Your own mouth ... condemns you: Job feared this would happen (9:20; see Matthew 26:65).

Job 15:7–8

When the Lord later gave a similar challenge, Job found it convincing (38:1–11).

Job 15:8

The book's readers know about God's secret council (1:6–12; 2:1–6; see 1 Kings 22:19–20; Psalm 89:5–7). But Job and his friends did not.

Job 15:9–10

Aged men who are gray-haired claim they alone have wisdom (8:8–10; 12:20; see 12:2).

Job 15:12

why do your eyes flash: This sentence might be a metaphor for unbelief, or it could mean winking like a person planning a trick or someone blinking in disbelief.

Job 15:14

- What is man, that he should be pure: Eliphaz repeated himself and Job (4:17–19; 7:17; 14:4).
- one born of woman: Both man and born of woman suggest weakness.

Job 15:15

The heavens, often linked with what is pure, were not completely pure (Exodus 24:10). Rebellious angels may have brought pollution (Job 1:6–7).

Job 15:17–19

when no foreigner passed among them: Eliphaz's contempt for foreign ideas is ironic. Wisdom literature is more international than other Old Testament writings.

Job 15:20–35

Evil people experience everything that happened to Job (see 1:16–19):

- Attacks by thieves (15:21).
- Loss of possessions (15:29).
- Collapse of houses (15:28).
- Fire (15:30, 34).

Job 15:21

- Eliphaz spoke about the fear that evil people feel, and Job had similar experiences (3:25; 6:4; 9:34; 13:11, 21; 23:15; 27:20; 30:15). Bildad and Zophar warned of more fear to come (18:11,14; 20:25).
- The Sabeans and Chaldeans were examples of "destroyers" (1:13–17). But this could mean any destructive force (1:18–19). A destroyer might be an agent of Satan or divine agents that punish evil (1 Corinthians 10:10; Revelation 9:11; Exodus 12:23; 2 Samuel 24:16; 2 Chronicles 32:21; Acts 12:23; Hebrews 11:28). Eliphaz referred to divine agents.

Job 15:22

he is marked for the sword: The evil people may die by murder or by God's punishment.

Job 15:23

Like evil people, Job may have experienced hunger. Or, following the ancient Greek Old Testament (Septuagint), the Berean Standard Bible says Job "wanders about as food for vultures." This would be similar to being "marked for the sword" (15:22).

Job 15:25

Earlier, Job complained that God was treating him like a powerful enemy (7:19–21; 13:24).

Job 15:30

- The flame, could refer to the sun burning or the flame of judgment from God (see 15:34; Numbers 16:31–35; Psalms 106:17–18; Ezekiel 20:47).
- the breath of God's mouth: This might be a desert wind or a direct "theophany" (a revelation of God's presence) that caused the "fire" of Job 15:34.

Job 15:34

"The flame" of judgment will destroy the unfair profits of those without faith (15:30).

Job 16:4

Job might have wanted to shake his head in to make fun or in horror (2 Kings 19:21; Psalms 22:7; 109:25; Isaiah 37:22; Jeremiah 18:16; Lamentations 2:15; Matthew 27:39).

Job 16:7

Job's family includes by extension his household and his servants (1:15–19).

Job 16:9–10

- They open their mouths against me: Job was mocked (compare Psalm 35:21; Isaiah 57:4; Lamentations 2:16; 3:46).
- strike my cheeks: This was more of an insult than an act of violence (Psalm 3:7; Micah 5:1; see also 1 Kings 22:24; Isaiah 50:6; Lamentations 3:30; Matthew 26:67).

Job 16:12

He seized me by the neck: This might refer to a wild animal capturing its prey (see 16:9). However, it is more likely a military image signaling defeat (Genesis 49:8; Psalm 18:40).

Job 16:13

my gall: This describes injuries to important organs.

Job 16:14

He breaks me with wound upon wound: Job imagines himself as a defensive military station with God attacking. Job regarded God as a warrior who neither defended nor saved him (see Exodus 15:3; Psalm 24:8; see Jeremiah 20:11; Zephaniah 3:17). Instead, God attacked him as if he were a threat (see Job 6:12; Isaiah 42:13).

Job 16:15

- Since Job insisted he was innocent, wearing sackcloth showed grief, not asking God to forgive him. He might have worn it to show he would never take it off because no one could comfort him (Genesis 37:34–35).

- I have buried my horn in the dust: A horn symbolized dignity and power (1 Samuel 2:1; Psalms 75:4–5; 89:17, 24; 92:10; 112:9; 148:14). Cutting it off caused deep humiliation (Psalm 75:10; Jeremiah 48:25; Zechariah 1:12).

Job 16:17

- Free of violence (Hebrew lo'-khamas): If violence is the meaning, Job might have been denying that he was a dangerous warrior who God should attack (16:12–14; see also Isaiah 59:6; Jonah 3:8).
- Contrary to Eliphaz's accusation and Bildad's assumption, Job's prayer was sincere because he was innocent (Job 15:4–5; 8:6; Genesis 20:5; Isaiah 59:3).

Job 16:18

Job's blood would testify that he was innocent and suffered without cause (compare Genesis 4:10–11; Isaiah 26:21; Ezekiel 24:7–8).

Job 16:18–22

Job thought his suffering would lead to his death (7:7, 21; 10:20–22). He asked God to show his innocence, even if he died before that happened.

Job 16:19–21

my witness is in heaven: Job wished for a kind third party to be "a mediator" between him and God (see 9:32–35). Job wanted a heavenly advocate who would eventually stand on the earth (16:19; compare Zechariah 3:1; Job 19:25; compare 1 Samuel 24:15; John 14:16, 26; 15:26; 16:7; 1 John 2:1).

Job 17:1

My spirit is broken: This can mean a truly sorry attitude (Psalm 51:17). But it usually means a very sad "spirit" (Proverbs 18:14).

Job 17:2

mockers surround me: songs of grief (laments) often describe making fun of someone as how evil people respond to the suffering of righteous people (Psalms 22:7; 69:10–12; 89:50–52). In wisdom literature, people make fun of right behavior (Proverbs 1:22; 9:7).

Job 17:3–5

Give me, I pray, the pledge You demand (literally please keep my pledge with yourself): A pledge (Hebrew 'erabon) can be a deposit that guarantees payment (Genesis 38:17–20; Exodus 22:26–27; Deuteronomy 24:10–14; see Proverbs 20:16; 27:13). So, this might suggest God forgiving sin (making atonement). It might also refer to Job's wish for an advocate to support his cause (see study note on Job 16:19–21).

Job 17:6

Spitting in someone's face was more insulting than a slap because it made the person ceremonially unclean (16:10; Numbers 12:14).

Job 17:8–9

Some scholars think these verses are out of place. However, Job might have been quoting his opponents' words ironically.

Job 17:10–16

Job no longer trusted his friends and thought he would die without hope (6:15–21; 13:4–5; 16:2–3; compare 12:2).

Job 17:13

for Sheol: People imagined the realm of dead people as a home (30:23; Psalm 49:11; Ecclesiastes 12:5).

Job 17:14

my father ... mother ... sister: This sad imitation of a family gathering in a cemetery shows how Job imagined his coming death.

Job 17:16

the gates of Sheol: Sheol is the place where dead people reside. Ancient people thought it had a gate with bars that allowed no escape.

Job 18:2–3

How long until you end these speeches?: Bildad spoke to Job as if addressing a group, possibly meaning "people like you."

Job 18:5

The phrase, "the lamp of the wicked is extinguished," might symbolize a life filled with confusion and darkness (Proverbs 4:19). More likely, it suggests an early death (Proverbs 13:9; 24:20).

Job 18:7

A shortened stride is the opposite of walking and running in a life of blessings (Proverbs 4:12).

Job 18:8–10

A series of devices for hunting shows the biblical principle of revenge (see study note on 34:11).

Job 18:11–13

Bildad uses the biblical idea of revenge (consequences for doing wrong) in Job's case, as do Eliphaz and Zophar.

Job 18:13

death devours: The prophet Isaiah later changed this image. He pictured the Lord as defeating death (Isaiah 25:8; see 1 Corinthians 15:54).

Job 18:15

The image of burning sulfur reminds the reader of what happened to Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19:24). It suggests what will happen to all evil people (Psalm 11:6; Revelation 19:20; 21:8).

Job 18:17

People often speak against (curse) evil people by saying that future generations will forget their memory (see 18:19; Psalms 34:16; 109:13; Proverbs 10:7).

Job 18:19

This bad fortune (curse) of Job no longer having children and Bildad's earlier cruel acts show that he believed Job's suffering was a fair punishment because he did wrong (see 18:16; Psalms 109:13; Isaiah 14:21–22; Job 8:4; 1:18–19).

Job 18:20

in the west ... in the east: These phrases might refer to people from the past and future or from different places.

Job 18:21

Bildad kept implying that Job had rejected God (15:4, 13, 25).

Job 19:3

The number ten symbolized a large, non-definite quantity rather than a specific count (for example, Genesis 31:7; Leviticus 26:26; Numbers 14:22; Daniel 1:20).

Job 19:6

- Job believed justice delayed and that God was unfair it how he had treated him (19:7; 19:8–12). Later, Elihu and God disagreed (34:12; 40:2).
- drawn His net around me: Job might have been replying to Bildad's accusation (18:8–10).

Job 19:7

- Violence!: Compare Jeremiah 20:8; Habakkuk 1:2–3.
- no response: See Psalm 22:2; Lamentations 3:8; Habakkuk 1:2–3.

Job 19:8

has blocked my way: See 3:23; 13:27; Psalm 88:8; Lamentations 3:7, 9.

Job 19:9

has stripped me of my honor: See 12:17–19; 29:7–14, 20.

Job 19:17

my own family: Job might have meant his tribe, his parents, his children, or his siblings.

Job 19:19

those I love have turned against me: See 2:11; also 6:14–15, 21–23, 27; compare Psalms 41:9; 55:12–14, 20.

Job 19:20

escaped by the skin of my teeth: This figure of speech means a narrow escape. In Hebrew, it might also suggest that Job became as thin as a skeleton with a skull full of teeth.

Job 19:21

the hand of God has struck me: God allowed Satan to harm Job (1:11; 2:5).

Job 19:22

persecute (literally pursue): Job said that God followed him like a someone hunting or a warrior (10:16; 16:13).

Job 19:23

Job wanted his words inscribed (carved) on a monument, not in a book. He wanted a record of his innocence that would last in response to Bildad's claim that he would become forgotten (18:17).

Job 19:25

Job's faith in a Redeemer (one who saves) could only become fulfilled in Christ. This was also true for his wish for an advocate and a witness in heaven (9:33; 16:19). The term Redeemer (Hebrew go'el) comes from both criminal and civil law. A person could redeem or take revenge because of the wrong shedding of blood or redeem lost property. This included buying back a slave or marrying the widow who inherited the property (Numbers 35:12–18; Leviticus 25:25, 47–49; 27:11–13; Ruth 3:13).

The Old Testament recognized the Lord as Redeemer (Exodus 6:6; Psalms 19:14; 103:4; Proverbs 23:10–11; Isa-

iah 43:1; Isaiah 54:5). New Testament Christians know the Redeemer as the Lord Jesus Christ (Ephesians 1:7, 14; Hebrews 9:12; 1 Peter 1:18). Job wanted his Redeemer to declare his innocence (see Job 1:1 and corresponding study note).

Job 19:26

Job believed God would prove him right, even if he died first.

Job 19:27

I will see Him for myself: This thought is like the psalmist's in "when I awake" (Psalm 17:15). For Job, this hope could only come true by seeing God at the end of time when his body transformed (Matthew 5:8; 1 Corinthians 13:12; 1 John 3:2; Revelation 1:7; 1 Corinthians 15:43–53; Philippians 3:21).

Job 19:29

According to biblical principles against lying, Job warned his friends to fear God's judgment (13:7–11; see Matthew 7:1–2; James 4:11–12). They eventually encountered his judgment, but they also received mercy (Job 42:7–8).

Job 20:7

he will perish forever, like his own dung: Compare 1 Kings 14:9–11; 2 Kings 9:36–37; Psalm 83:10; Jeremiah 8:1–2.

Job 20:10

Riches stolen do not provide benefits that last because they obtain them in a dishonest way (20:18–21).

Job 20:14–16

venom of cobras ... poison of cobras ... vipers: In the end, evil people harm only themselves, not others (Matthew 3:7; Romans 3:13; Proverbs 23:29–35).

Job 20:17

The streams of olive oil and rivers flowing with honey and cream represent great blessings (Exodus 5:19; Deuteronomy 27:3; Joel 3:18).

Job 20:20

Like the grave or death, evil people always focus on themselves and never find satisfaction (Proverbs 27:20; 30:15–16; Ecclesiastes 5:19; Isaiah 57:20–21; Habakkuk 2:5).

Job 20:24

Evil people cannot avoid trouble (see Isaiah 24:17–18; Jeremiah 15:2–3; Amos 5:19; 9:1–2). When they escape one threat, another confronts them.

Job 20:25

Terrors: These are terrors of death. Although the specific words "of death" are not in the Hebrew text, they are understood because the description talks about an arrowhead that glistens with blood (literally with gall). This indicates a deadly hit on an important organ in the body (6:4; 16:13; Psalm 7:12). The image conveys the serious threat and intense fear that comes with being in mortal danger.

Job 20:26

Images like darkness and fire often symbolize God's presence, especially his judgment (Deuteronomy 4:11; 5:22–23; Hebrews 12:18; Exodus 9:23–24; 10:21–29).

Job 20:27

The heavens ... will rise up: Compare Deuteronomy 4:26; 30:19; 31:28.

Job 21:2

Job's friends claimed they were delivering God's message of consolation or comfort. But Job found no comfort in their words. He asked them to comfort him by giving him silent attention (15:11; 16:2; 13:5).

Job 21:6

- When I think about what I am saying: Job felt upset about his horrible task of complaining against God and talking about his terrors (13:3, 15–16, 22; 23:1–5; 6:4; 27:20; 30:15).
- my body trembles: This reaction is similar to that of the prophets Habakkuk, Ezekiel, and Daniel (Habakkuk 1:5; 3:16; Ezekiel 3:14; Daniel 8:27; 10:8–9).

Job 21:8

Despite what Eliphaz, Bildad and Zophar claimed, Job observed that evil people have children and grandchildren (5:4); 18:19; 20:10). These should be rewards for righteous people (Proverbs 17:6). But Job felt they would not be his reward (Job 1:18–19; see also 42:13–16).

Job 21:17

the lamp of the wicked put out: Job disagreed with Bildad and the standard perspective of wisdom (18:5–6, 18; Proverbs 13:9; 20:20; 24:20; see God's comments at Job 38:15).

Job 21:19

- It is said: Job was quoting and responding to his friends' arguments.
- God lays up one's punishment for his children: Eliphaz and Zophar said this, but Job believed God should punish the people who sin (5:4; 20:10; see Ezekiel 18:19–20).

Job 21:22

- This question assumes the answer that no one can teach God a lesson (Isaiah 40:13–14; 45:9; Romans 11:34; 1 Corinthians 2:16).
- The phrase those on high might refer to good or bad angels (demons) (1 Corinthians 6:3; 2 Peter 2:4; Jude 1:6; Revelation 20:1–3). Or, more likely, it refers to powerful people on earth (Job 34:17–19).

Job 21:24

his bones are rich with marrow: People once believed bones were the source of health.

Job 21:25

in the bitterness of his soul: Job often complained about how life seemed useless (3:20; 7:11; 9:18; 10:1).

Job 21:26

worms cover them both: Compare 17:14; Isaiah 14:11; see Job 19:26.

Job 21:28

where are the tents in which the wicked dwell: Job was echoing the words of Bildad, Eliphaz and Zophar (8:22; 15:34; 20:26).

Job 21:33

The clods of the valley are sweet to him: Job considered death as a relief (3:17–18).

Job 21:34

They told lies about Job and God (13:4; 42:7).

Job 22:1–26.14

In this third round of speeches, Job's friends plainly accuse him of being evil and sharing the fate of those who do evil.

Job 22:2–3

- Eliphaz did not understand that God would delight in Job's right relationship with him, just as God does with every righteous person (1:8; 2:3; 1 Chronicles 29:17; Psalms 147:10–11; Proverbs 11:1, 20; 12:22). God would also benefit from Job's steady faith, which exposed the lie in Satan's challenge (Job 1:9–12; 2:4–6).
- Job firmly claimed that he was blameless (23:10–12). God said the same thing (1:1, 8; 2:3).

Job 22:6

The law and prophets forbade taking clothing as security for loans (Exodus 22:26–27; Deuteronomy 24:10–13; Ezekiel 18:7–8; Amos 2:8). In contrast, Job gave clothing to poor people (Job 31:19–20).

Job 22:9

The Old Testament assigns Israel the duty of caring for widows and the fatherless (Deuteronomy 10:18; 14:29). It often condemns neglecting them as the worst evil against society (Exodus 22:22–24; Deuteronomy 27:19). Job agreed that neglecting them was wrong but claimed he was innocent (Job 24:3, 21; 29:12–13; 31:16–18, 21).

Job 22:12–14

What does God know?: Job did not claim that God cannot see, but others have (see Psalms 10:11; 73:11; 94:7).

Job 22:18

so I stay far from the counsel of the wicked: Eliphaz repeated Job's words to him (21:16b).

Job 22:19–20

The righteous see it and are glad: Those in a right relationship with God will be glad to see justice done and wrong things made right (see also Psalm 58:10–11; Revelation 19:1–4). Eliphaz's perspective overlooked God's wish "that the wicked should turn from their ways and live" (see Ezekiel 33:11).

Job 22:22

- The term instruction (Hebrew torah, also meaning "law," Deuteronomy 17:11), used in Job only here, often refers to the "Pentateuch" (Genesis through Deuteronomy).
- Receive ... lay up: See Deuteronomy 4:1–2; 6:6–9; Psalm 119:11; Proverbs 2:1–9. Job had done this thing (Job 23:12).

Job 22:23

return to the Almighty: Bildad and Zophar had already made a wrong application of this principle of the Bible (8:5–6; 11:13–14; Isaiah 55:6–7; Hosea 14:1–2; Zechariah

1:3; Acts 26:20). Now Eliphaz also makes a wrong application of it.

Job 22:24

gold of Ophir: Ophir was probably in southern Arabia (see 1 Kings 9:28; 22:48). The gold of Ophir set the standard for fine gold (Isaiah 13:12). Queens wore it at weddings (Psalm 45:9).

Job 22:25

God promises to be a "treasure" for his people (Psalm 16:5; Isaiah 33:6; Matthew 19:21; Mark 10:21). Even if they own nothing, they will be "rich" (2 Corinthians 6:10; James 2:5).

Job 22:27

- Ironically, Job will pray, God will hear, and Eliphaz will benefit (42:8).
- you will fulfill your vows: People often vowed after God forgave them (Hosea 14:2; Jonah 1:16; 2:9). They also vowed when asking help from God (Judges 11:29–40; 1 Samuel 1:1–28). Vows mean a serious commitments or to swear a promise (Numbers 30:2; Deuteronomy 23:23; Psalms 22:25; 61:5, 8; 116:14, 18; Ecclesiastes 5:4–5).

Job 22:29

This difficult text probably shows how effective the prayer of a person in a right relationship with God can be. The idea appears throughout the Bible (Psalms 34:15, 17; 145:18; Proverbs 15:8, 29; James 5:16; see also Genesis 18:23–32; 19:29; 20:7, 17; 32:28; Exodus 9:28–32; 17:11; 32:10–14; Romans 5:19).

Job 23:2

Job released his earlier doubts (9:14–20, 32). Now he expresses confidence that he could present his complaint to God with success.

Job 23:4

plead my case: Job wanted to present his legal case to God (13:3, 18, 22; 16:21; 31:35). Abraham pleaded directly with God about Sodom (Genesis 18:25–32). Moses did the same for Israel (Exodus 32:12–13; Numbers 14:13–19).

Job 23:6–7

- Earlier, Job thought God was too powerful for him to "summon" (9:19). He asked for "a mediator" and requested that God not "frighten" him (9:33–34; 13:21). Here, he showed more hope that God would give him a fair legal hearing.
- delivered: Job wanted God to declare him innocent, not forgive him as if he were guilty (13:18; see Psalms 17:2–3; 26:1–3).

Job 23:10

has tested me: Job did not want the kind of punishment that would make him clean as through "a refiner's fire" (Proverbs 17:3; Zechariah 13:9; Malachi 3:2–3). He wanted a test to show he was already as pure as gold and did not need to change his life (Job 22:23).

Job 23:13–14

No one can change God's mind (9:12–13; 11:10; 12:14; 34:29; Numbers 23:19–20; James 1:17).

Job 23:15–17

- Terrified in His presence: See Psalms 77:3; 88:16; 119:120.
- Job had earlier complained about being in darkness (Job 19:8). Eliphaz and Bildad said this fate is for the evil person (15:22; 22:1; 18:6, 18).

Job 24:1

reserve times: God sets times for judgment (Ecclesiastes 3:17; 8:6; Daniel 2:21; Luke 21:22–24). But we do not know when they are (Acts 1:7). He will reveal them at the right time (1 Thessalonians 5:1–28; 1 Timothy 6:15).

Job 24:2

The books of the law, wisdom literature, and prophecy all condemned moving markers of boundaries (Deuteronomy 19:14; 27:17; Proverbs 22:28; 23:10; see study note on Hosea 5:10).

Job 24:2–17

This list of criminal behaviors first emphasizes crimes against weak people (24:2–12). Then it examines the criminals themselves (24:13–17).

Job 24:3

The law prohibited taking essential possessions as security or a down payment for a loan (22:6–9; Deuteronomy 24:6, 10–13, 17–21).

Job 24:6

glean the vineyards of the wicked: Job described the desperate situation of poor people. If someone stole their fields like in the case of Naboth's vineyard, the poor person would harvest for the thieves instead of

for themselves (24:2; see 1 Kings 21:1–29). They would only get the bits that remained. If the poor had to glean from fields of the wicked people, they would receive nothing (Leviticus 19:10; 23:22). But if they would try to gather from the fields of just people, they would be something left for them (Leviticus 19:9–10; 23:22; Ruth 2:1–23).

Job 24:7

Those who did not lend fairly sometimes took the clothing or blankets of those in debt as a security for the loan. This left those in debt without proper clothing or covering (22:6; Exodus 22:26–27; Deuteronomy 24:11–13; Amos 2:8).

Job 24:9

the nursing child of the poor is seized for a debt: See 2 Kings 4:1; Nehemiah 5:1–5; Matthew 18:25.

Job 24:11

Forcing workers to tread the winepresses while they go thirsty violates the principle of letting workers enjoy some of the produce they are harvesting (see Deuteronomy 25:4; compare 2 Timothy 2:6).

Job 24:12

yet God charges no one with wrongdoing: Job thought that, unlike God's usual character, God did not help those treated wrong or stop evil people from hurting their victims (Exodus 2:23–24; Psalm 12:5; Job 24:2–12; 24:13–17).

Job 24:18–24

These ideas seem to go against Job's observations. Some scholars think Bildad or Zophar might have said them. However, Job might have been speaking against evil people, making fun of his friends' opinions by quoting them. Or he might have meant that the fate of evil people also affects those in a right relationship with God. His friends described this earlier (5:2–7; 15:17–25; 8:8–19; 18:5–21; 20:4–29; 21:23–26).

Job 25:4

Eliphaz stated that being innocent or pure is almost impossible (4:17–19; 15:14–16). A person can achieve it only after suffering (22:21–23). Bildad argued that only those who are completely blameless can hope to be pure (8:20).

Job 26:2

Job's friends did not help him (12:2; 16:4). Bildad's claim that innocence was impossible upset Job deeply (10:1–7; 13:3, 13–19; 16:18–21; 19:23–27; 23:2–7).

Job 26:4

Eliphaz, Zophar, and Elihu all claimed that the right spirit was guiding them (4:15; 20:3; 32:18; 33:4; see also Jeremiah 29:8–9; 1 Corinthians 12:10; 1 John 4:1).

Job 26:5–6

- The Hebrew word, Sheol, is where all dead people go. It is beneath the waters.
- The Hebrew word, Abaddon, is the place where evil people go to their destruction.

Job 26:7

The Hebrew word tsapon means north. It sometimes refers to the northern mountain of the Canaanite gods, similar to Mount Olympus (Genesis 13:14). The Berean Standard Bible refers to it as the sky, stretched over empty space (see Genesis 1:6–8; Psalm 104:2–3; Isaiah 40:22–23).

Job 26:10

has inscribed a horizon: See Genesis 1:6–10; Psalm 104:6–9; Proverbs 8:29.

Job 26:11

People once believed that mountains at the edge of the horizon were the foundations or "pillars" of heaven or the earth (Judges 16:25–26; Job 9:6). They thought these mountains extended from beneath the sea's waters up to the clouds, supporting the dome of the heavens (Jonah 2:6).

Job 26:12

- He stirred the sea (compare Exodus 14:21; Mark 4:39; compare Isaiah 51:15; Jeremiah 31:35). God performed a miracle for his people.
- He shattered Rahab: God showed control over the sea symbolized as a monster ("Rahab"), challenging myths about the sea being divine. See also Psalms 74:13–14; 89:9–10; Isaiah 27:1; 51:9–10.

Job 26:13

- His breath (or wind): God's authority clears the skies after a storm (26:12).
- The fleeing serpent relates to "Yam" and "Rahab" (see study note on 7:12). It provides background for the image of Satan as a "dragon" (Isaiah 27:1;

also Psalm 74:13–14; see Genesis 3:15; Romans 16:20; Revelation 12:9; 20:2).

Job 27:1

Job continued his discourse: He no longer responded to his three friends. Instead, he returned to the themes of his opening statement (3:1–26).

Job 27:2

- The Bible allows for making a vow to the living God (Ruth 3:13; 1 Samuel 20:21; 25:26; 1 Kings 17:1; 18:15; Jeremiah 4:2). But sometimes people make silly or false vows (1 Samuel 14:39, 45; Jeremiah 5:2).
- Elihu later criticized Job for claiming that God deprived me of justice (Job 34:5).
- embittered my soul (7:11; 10:1; 21:25): Compare Naomi and the widow from Shunem after losing her son (Ruth 1:20–21; 2 Kings 4:27).

Job 27:5–6

Job found it wrong and offensive to admit that his friends were correct. It was a terrible act to condemn an innocent man like him (Exodus 23:7; Proverbs 6:16–19; 17:15).

Job 27:9–23

Some interpreters think this is a new speech by Zophar. Without it, Zophar has no speech in this cycle.

Job 28:1–28

This section is an isolated speech. There is no speaker listed, so it might continue from earlier words. Some see it as a creative summary by the author of Job. It emphasizes the limits of human wisdom and sets the stage for the Lord's speeches.

Job 28:5

People who mined would melt rock by burning a fire in a mine for days or weeks to extract the solid matter (ore). Some used fire and then cold water to crack the rocks.

Job 28:13

Wisdom does not come from people. God is the true source of wisdom (28:23–28).

Job 28:16–19

The metals, gems, and glass listed here were valuable in the ancient world. However, the speaker says wisdom is more valuable than wealth.

Job 28:23–27

When God looks across the entire earth, he sees his wisdom in his creation (28:23). God later showed his wisdom to Job by taking him on a tour of the universe (chapters 38–41).

Job 28:28

the fear of the Lord (Hebrew, 'adonay): In the book of Job, this name for God appears only here. This might suggest that chapter 28 is a poem by the person narrating.

Job 29:1–31.40

Job compares his past happiness, honor, and wealth with his current loss of social dignity and divine friendship (chapters 29 and 30). He ends his speech with broad vows of innocence (chapter 31).

Job 29:2

In other parts of the text, Job uses the Hebrew word shamar to describe what he sees as God's severe surveillance (10:14; 13:27; 14:16). However, here it refers to God's kind care, meaning watched over (Psalm 121:3–8).

Job 29:7

The city gate served as the town's administrative center (see Ruth 4:1–2, 11).

Job 29:14

Job described his righteousness using royal imagery. In the Bible, a robe often symbolizes righteousness (Psalm 132:9; Isaiah 59:17; Isaiah 61:10; Romans 13:14; Revelation 19:8).

Job 29:16

Job was active in searching out and helping strangers in need.

Job 29:18

and multiply my days as the sand (literally after I have counted my days like sand): Job believed the length of his years showed God's blessing. This was similar to the numerous people descended from Abraham or the abundance of supplies Joseph had in Egypt (Genesis 15:5; 32:12; Genesis 41:49).

Job 29:25

In the past, Job was a comforter of the mourners (4:3–4). This verse is a prophetic command closely linked to

the work of the Christ (Isaiah 40:1; 61:1–3; Luke 4:18–19; see also 2 Corinthians 1:3–4).

Job 30:2–3

In the past, the most important members of society praised Job (29:11). Now, the least important made fun of him and spit in his face (30:1, 10). Compare with Psalms 35:15; 69:12; Mark 14:65; 15:17–20.

Job 30:5–6

They live in scary valleys (wadis), caves (holes), and among rocks.

The miserable life of those making fun of Job was like:

- Israel's situation under Midianite abuse (Judges 6:2).
- David's life when he fled from King Saul (1 Samuel 22:1–2).
- The prophet Elijah's life as he waited for the Lord's instruction (1 Kings 17:3–8).

Job 30:9

they mock me: See also 17:6; compare with Psalm 69:12; Lamentations 3:14, 63.

Job 30:10

- keep far from me: See also 19:13–15; compare Psalm 88:8; Proverbs 19:7; Matthew 26:56.
- Spitting in someone's face showed extreme dislike or hatred (Deuteronomy 25:9; Isaiah 50:6; Matthew 26:67; 27:30; Mark 14:65).

Job 30:12–14

- The series of images here shows a military attack on a city with strong defenses. Job had already used this image to describe God's attack on him (Job 19:10–12).
- The word translated as snares might refer to ramps raised against a city's walls. A siege ramp was a large sloped structure of earth and stones that armies built against city walls. These ramps allowed attacking soldiers to climb up to the top of the walls during a battle.

Job 30:15

Terrors: See also 6:4; 7:14; compare with Psalm 88:15.

Job 30:18

He seizes me by the collar: The Hebrew in this verse is hard to translate. It might mean Job feels like God is choking him and he is a throw him into the mud (compare 30:19).

Job 30:19

dust and ashes: Earlier, Job sat among the ashes in pain (2:8). Later, he would sit in dust and ashes to "repent" (42:6).

Job 30:20–21

You do not answer: Job often complained about this (9:16; 19:7; 23:2–9; 31:35). But God soon responded (38:1).

Job 30:22

Job felt like he was caught in a storm and blown around like useless "straw" or "chaff" (9:17; 21:18; 27:21; Psalm 1:4; Isaiah 17:13).

Job 30:28

Before his testing began, people respected Job in the public square (29:7–10, 21–25). He helped those in need (29:11–17).

Job 30:29

Job might have been expressing how he saw himself, how others saw him, or both. By saying he was a brother of jackals, a companion to owls, Job might have been describing his deep grief (Micah 1:8). People associated jackals with things devastated or ruins (see Psalm 63:10; Isaiah 13:22; 34:13; 35:7; Jeremiah 9:11; 10:22; 49:33; 51:37; Lamentations 5:18; Ezekiel 13:4; Malachi 1:3).

Job 30:30

People with a comfortable life had skin protected from the sun and wind. Dark skin suggested physical and social decline (Lamentations 4:8; 5:10).

Job 31:1

- Job made a promise with himself about his eyes, including an oath against himself (curse) (see Matthew 5:28–29). Job might have focused on wrong desire because the eyes are often the first to commit sin (Genesis 3:6).
- Looking with wrong desire at a virgin violates the spirit of the seventh commandment (Deuteronomy 5:18, see Matthew 5:27–28). It could violate the tenth commandment as well (Deuteronomy 5:21).

Job 31:1–40

Job called down wrong against himself (curses) if he was guilty of the accusations against him. Apart from mentioning idolatry (worship of false gods), Job spoke about how loyal he was to God by focusing on the second half of the Ten Commandments (31:26–

27). The summary of these is: "love your neighbor as yourself" (Leviticus 19:18; Romans 13:9).

Job 31:5–8

- If Job had lied in a business deal, it would violate the eighth commandment (Deuteronomy 5:19). If he lied in court, it would violate the ninth commandment (Deuteronomy 5:20). This sin would deserve judgment of fire (Revelation 21:8).
- If Job desired his neighbor's possessions, he would violate the tenth commandment (Deuteronomy 5:21).
- then may another eat: This was also speaking against himself (a curse).

Job 31:9–10

- Whether she tempted him or he waited for her, if Job desired his neighbor's wife, he would violate the seventh and tenth commandments (24:15–16; Deuteronomy 5:18, Matthew 5:27–28; Deuteronomy 5:21).
- grind for: This might refer to servitude or sexual relations (Exodus 11:5).

Job 31:11

The Hebrew term zimmah is associated with sexual crimes like incest ("it is depraved," Leviticus 18:17), gang-rape ("a lewd and disgraceful act," Judges 20:6), and prostitution ("indecency," Ezekiel 23:49).

Job 31:12

The Old Testament rarely links fire with hell (Abaddon) or the grave (see Deuteronomy 32:22).

Job 31:13–15

- Rejected ... manservant or maidservant: This might refer to violating the fourth commandment (Deuteronomy 5:12–15).
- He who made me in the womb also make them: Job applied the idea of being made in God's image to the poor person and even to slaves (Proverbs 14:31; 22:2).

Job 31:21

I had support in the gate: Job had respect and they regarded him as part of the high class (29:7–10).

Job 31:22–23

If someone used an arm for a sinful action, having it torn from its socket would be a fitting punishment (31:21). This would be better than encountering God's judgment (compare Matthew 5:28–30).

Job 31:24

If I have put my trust in gold: Job did not state the result of this vow because the "if-then" pattern was now obvious (31:5–23). He rejected the judgment Eliphaz implied (22:24–25; see Psalms 52:7; 62:10; 1 Timothy 6:10, 17).

Job 31:25

rejoiced in my great wealth: See Deuteronomy 8:17–18; compare Isaiah 10:12–14; Daniel 4:28–30; Hosea 12:8.

Job 31:26

if I have beheld the sun ... or the moon: This vow denies violating the first commandment (compare Jeremiah 8:2; 44:17; Ezekiel 8:16; Acts 7:43; Deuteronomy 5:7; see Deuteronomy 4:19; 17:2–7).

Job 31:26–28

The sins of adultery and worshiping the sun and moon had the death penalty (compare 31:1, 9–12). Both were sins that tempted the inner being of a person through the eyes. Judges tried both types of sin in court.

Job 31:27

- My heart was secretly enticed: See 31:9.
- threw a kiss from my mouth: Compare 1 Kings 19:18; Hosea 13:2.

Job 31:28

- In Israel, the role of judges was to punish those worshiping idols (false gods) by execution (see 31:11; Deuteronomy 17:2–7).
- Denying God on high violated the first commandment (Deuteronomy 5:7).

Job 31:29–30

- I have rejoiced in my enemy's ruin: See Proverbs 24:17–18; compare 2 Samuel 16:5–8.
- Speaking evil against (a curse) anyone went against the spirit of the sixth commandment (Deuteronomy 5:17; see Matthew 5:21–22).
- It was against God's will to seek revenge (Matthew 5:43–44; Romans 12:14; James 3:6–10; 1 Peter 3:9).

Job 31:31–32

no stranger had to lodge on the street: The Old Testament values hosting strangers (hospitality) (Genesis 18:1–13; 19:2–3; Judges 19:20–21). The New Testament commands it (Matthew 25:35; Romans 12:13; 1 Timothy 3:2; Hebrews 13:2; 1 Peter 4:9).

Job 31:35

Here is my signature: Job wanted to make the events official (19:23–24).

Job 31:36

carry it on my shoulder (compare Exodus 28:12; Isaiah 22:22): He would take full responsibility for his actions.

Job 31:37

When someone made a wrong accusation against a prince, he could appeal to his king.

Job 31:38

The land was the main "witness" to the crimes done on it (20:27; see Genesis 4:10; compare James 5:4).

Job 31:40

let briers grow: Job cursed himself (spoke evil against himself), echoing when God first "cursed" Adam (Genesis 3:17–18; see also Isaiah 7:25; Zephaniah 2:9).

Job 32:1

Job's three friends did not succeed in comforting him (see 2:11; 6:14–30; 13:4; 16:2; 19:21; 42:10).

Job 32:1–37.24

After three rounds of speeches between Job and his friends, a new voice speaks. Elihu, a young man, has listened to everything the others said.

Job 32:2

- The Buzite: Buz had ties with Aram and Arabia, similar to Uz (Genesis 22:21; Jeremiah 25:23; Job 1:1).
- Elihu often said he was angry. He probably considered his anger as righteous "zeal" (Psalm 69:9).

Job 32:4–7

Elihu respected elders, following a common principle (see also 12:12; 15:10; Leviticus 19:32; 1 Timothy 5:1; 1 Peter 5:5).

Job 32:8–9

The spirit in a man might not be God's Spirit of prophecy that Elihu later mentions, as Eliphaz had done (33:14–15; 4:12–17; compare 32:18–20). This spirit might simply exist because of creation (33:4; Genesis 2:7; Acts 17:25).

Job 32:15–16

Some translations read, "you are silent, now that you stand and no longer reply." Thus, Elihu addresses Job's friends. The Berean Standard Bible translates they are silent, now that they stand and no longer reply. This interprets Elihu talking to Job about his friends.

Job 32:18–20

- The length of Elihu's speech shows he had many words to share (32:1–37:24).
- Elihu probably believed the spirit (Hebrew ruakh) within him urged him to speak (32:8, 19–20; Psalm 39:3). But the reader might regard him as just full of wind (an alternate meaning of the Hebrew ruakh; see study note on Job 15:2–3).
- Like Zophar, Elihu needed to speak to find relief (compare 20:2).

Job 33:1

hear: Elihu asked the others to hear him, just as Job had also requested (33:1; 34:2, 16; 13:6).

Job 33:5

Elihu invited Job to present his case, acting as if he were God or the judge Job had been seeking (9:32–35).

Job 33:7

- no fear of me should terrify you: Eliphaz, Bildad, and Zophar had tried to use God's terrors to scare Job (15:21, 24; 22:10; 18:11, 14; 20:25; 6:4; 7:14; 9:34; 13:21; 23:15).
- Elihu promised not to be harsh with Job, but he later violated his promise (34:7–9, 33–37).

Job 33:9

Job claimed to be pure and without sin, using various terms (9:21; 10:6–7; 11:4; 13:23–24; 15:14–16; 16:17; 31:1–40).

Job 33:11

Job often complained about God's constant surveillance (7:20; 10:14; 13:27). He wanted relief from having every move examined (14:16; 29:2).

Job 33:13

Job's main complaint was that God did not answer him (9:16; 19:7; 23:2–7).

Job 33:15

In a dream: For examples, see Genesis 15:12; 20:3; 31:24; 40:1–41:36; Daniel 2:1–45; Joel 2:28; Acts 16:9–10.

Job 33:18

from perishing by the sword: This phrase can also mean "from crossing over the river of death" (New Living Translation). Both translations make sense in the context (compare 36:12).

Job 33:22

messengers of death: Compare: Exodus 12:23; 2 Samuel 24:16; 1 Corinthians 10:10.

Job 33:23

An angel or messenger from heaven would act as the mediator Job desired (see 5:1; 9:33–34; 16:18–21).

Job 33:24

The ultimate ransom is Christ (Matthew 20:28; Romans 3:24–25; 1 Timothy 2:6; 1 Peter 1:18–19).

Job 33:26

he sees God's face and shouts for joy: Compare Numbers 6:24–26; Psalm 67:1; Acts 2:28; Jude 1:24.

Job 33:32

It sounds ironic that Elihu says he would like to vindicate Job. He joined the discussion because Job would not admit he had sinned (32:1–5).

Job 34:3–4

ear tests ... mouth tastes: Elihu repeated Job's earlier complaint about the other counselors' weak argument that, "Wisdom is found with the elderly" (12:11–12; see 6:30; Hebrews 5:14).

Job 34:5–6

Job said he was righteous: See 9:20–21; 13:18; 27:6.

Job 34:6

- Eliphaz accused Job of lying (15:5). This was something Job feared would happen (6:28–29).
- My wound (literally My arrow): For the connection with the Lord's "arrows," see 6:4; 16:13; Jeremiah 10:19; 15:18; 30:12, 15; Lamentations 3:12; Micah 1:9; Nahum 3:19.

Job 34:9

Elihu later repeated this accusation (35:3; compare Psalm 73:13; Zephaniah 1:12; Malachi 3:14). But he misrepresented Job's words (Job 9:22–23; 21:15). Job had actually criticized those who had this perspective (21:14–16).

Job 34:10–15

The passage connects three ideas to the belief that God can do no wrong (34:10, 12):

1. God rewards or punishes people based on their actions (34:11);
2. As the creator, God does not have to answer to anyone (34:13).
3. Every living being relies on God for life. God can take life away without being wrong (34:14–15; compare Romans 9:19–29).

Job 34:11

according to a man's deeds: Compare Psalm 62:12; Proverbs 24:12; Jeremiah 32:19; Ezekiel 33:20; Matthew 16:27; Romans 2:6; Galatians 6:7–8; 1 Peter 1:17. The final judgment will occur at the end of time (2 Corinthians 5:10; Revelation 2:23; 22:12).

Job 34:17

- The implication was that God could not rule if he hated justice (see Romans 3:4–7; 7:7, 13; 9:14; Galatians 2:17; 6:14).
- Later, God also asked if Job intended to condemn the mighty judge (Job 40:8).

Job 34:19

who is not partial to princes: God's justice is not partial (Acts 10:34; Romans 2:11; Galatians 2:6; Ephesians 6:9; Colossians 3:25; 1 Peter 1:17).

Job 34:22

Evil people may try to hide in darkness (Jeremiah 23:24). But they will not succeed (Psalm 139:11–12; compare Amos 9:2–3). God reveals everything (1 Corinthians 4:5).

Job 34:23

God need not examine a man further: Elihu said this to disagree with Job's wish for God to quickly announce a time of judgment (21:19; 24:1). Elihu believed that God already understood all people perfectly without needing to set up a special court or investigation.

Job 34:24

- God knows everything without needing to ask anyone (34:25).
- sets up others in their place: Daniel 2:21; 5:28–30.

Job 34:26

When God shows justice openly, it causes evil people to have proper fear (Deuteronomy 21:21; 1 Timothy

5:20). This leads to public joy among people in a right relationship with God (compare Exodus 14:30–31).

Job 34:31

Suppose someone says: Elihu posed the indirect question, "Job, why won't you admit it?"

Job 34:36

tried to the utmost: Zophar also said that Job should have suffered worse punishment than he did (11:6).

Job 35:4–8

Elihu tried to answer his own question (35:2).

But his response did not add anything new compared to:

- Zophar (11:8–9).
- Eliphaz (22:12).
- Bildad (25:5–6).
- Job (9:8–10).

Elihu did not realize that all sin offends God (Genesis 39:9; Matthew 25:41–46; compare Proverbs 19:17).

Job 35:15–16

Elihu echoed Job's words but then disagreed with them (9:24; 12:6–10; 21:7–15, 17).

Job 35:16

Elihu echoed his earlier accusation (34:35). Later, God would agree (38:2).

Job 36:4

one who is perfect in knowledge is with you: Elihu probably was claiming to be sincere or that his logic had no flaw.

Job 36:7

The Bible teaches that God always watches over the righteous (2 Chronicles 16:9; Psalms 33:18; 34:15; 1 Peter 3:12). This idea addresses Job's frustration about God's surveillance (Job 7:17–21).

Job 36:11

If they obey and serve Him, then they end their days in prosperity: This is a true biblical principle of dedication to God (repentance) (see 11:13–19; 22:21–25; Deuteronomy 4:30; Jeremiah 7:23; 26:13).

Job 36:12

die without knowledge: See also 4:21; Proverbs 5:23; 10:21.

Job 36:31

The Hebrew yadin typically means he judges or he governs. But some commentators propose an alternate reading, yazun (meaning "he nourishes"). This aligns with the theme of God's provision (Job 38:26; Psalms 65:9–13; 104:13–15, 27–28). The more common meaning of yadin is "judge," which would mean that God does all things to bless his people and judge his enemies (Job 37:11–13; 38:22–23; see Genesis 6:17; 19:24; Exodus 9:23–25; Joshua 10:11–14; 1 Samuel 12:18).

Job 37:2

The Old Testament often links thunder to God's voice (36:29, 33; 37:5; 38:1; Exodus 19:16–19; Psalm 104:7).

Job 37:7

He seals up the hand of every man ... know His work: The end of the farming season gives people time to think about God's control over everything.

Job 37:13

God's actions can have multiple purposes. For example, storms can both destroy enemies and bring victory to God's people (Joshua 10; Judges 4; 1 Samuel 7:10–11; Psalms 18:7–15; 105:32–33).

Job 37:17

The hot south wind made it very hot and uncomfortable.

Job 37:20

Should He be told that I want to speak? Would a man ask to be swallowed up?: Contesting God's judgment might lead to severe punishment, even death (see 13:14).

Job 37:22

Out of the north (Hebrew from Zaphon): In the literature of the ancient city of Ugarit, Zaphon was the northern mountain home of the false god "Baal." Here, it symbolically refers to the height of God's home in the heavens (see Isaiah 14:13–14).

Job 37:23

- The Almighty is beyond our reach: Compare 11:7; 26:14; Romans 11:33; 1 Timothy 6:16.
- His justice and great righteousness: Compare Job 9:4, 19; 12:13; Psalms 62:11; 66:3; 93:1; 99:4.

Job 38:1–3

the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind: The Old Testament often links storms with God's presence (2 Kings 2:1, 11; Ezekiel 1:4; Nahum 1:3). Job finally had the chance to speak with God (Job 13:22–23).

Job 38:1–40.5

God challenges Job. Job admits he cannot judge the moral world. God shows Job's ignorance of the natural world's elements related to the realm of heaven, weather, animals, and birds (38:4–21; 22–38; 39–39:30).

Job 38:1–42.6

Then the LORD answered Job: In this last part, the LORD challenges Job's strong self-defense by showing his works. This reminds Job of God's supreme greatness.

Job 38:2

obscures My counsel: God's accusation is similar to a charge made by Eliphaz and Elihu (15:2; 34:35; 35:16). Job eventually admitted his guilt (42:3).

Job 38:7

God describes the morning stars as if they are people, similar to the description of angels (1:6; 2:1).

Job 38:10–11

set in place its bars and doors: God describes the sea as a dangerous creature that is kept under control.

Job 38:14

stand out like the folds of a garment: The rising sun highlights the colors, shapes, and textures of objects.

Job 38:21

you were already born: Compare with Proverbs 8:25. This sarcasm is similar to Eliphaz's words in Job 15:7.

Job 38:22–23

God stores up snow and hail, like the deep seas and winds (Psalms 33:7; 135:7; Jeremiah 10:13; 51:16). God uses these elements as weapons through storms he sends on the day of war and battle (Job 36:32; Isaiah 30:30; Ezekiel 13:11–13; Revelation 16:21; for example, Joshua 10:11; Judges 5:20–21; 1 Samuel 7:10.

Job 38:24–27

- The east wind blows from the desert, drying up crops and seas (Genesis 41:6, 23, 27; Jeremiah 4:11; Jonah 4:8; Exodus 14:21; Isaiah 11:15). It is not like the heavy rain that causes floods.
- Helpful rain quenches a barren land (Psalms 104:10–11; 107:35; Isaiah 35:7; 58:11). This contrasts with both hot winds and flooding rains (Job 38:24, 25).

Job 38:36

heart ... mind: These words can also mean "ibis" and "rooster." The Egyptians believed the ibis bird knew about the Nile's flooding, the most important event in Egypt. Israel's rabbis (religious teachers with authority) believed the rooster bird could predict rain or its distinctive sound (crowing) marked day and night. The question would then be Who taught the ibis and the rooster? See also Psalm 51:6; Proverbs 2:6; James 1:5, 17.

Job 39:5–7

the wild donkey ... scorns the tumult of the city: This is the first example in a series of animals that think little of other animals not their equal (compare 39:18, 22; 41:29). These images show how God scorns the opposition of a person like Job (see Psalm 2:4).

Job 39:9–12

The wild ox now no longer exists and was already rare by the time of Moses. It was the strongest land animal in early Canaan. They never tamed this Old Testament symbol of strength (Numbers 23:22; 24:8; Deuteronomy 33:17; Psalms 29:6; 92:10; compare Genesis 1:28; 9:2; Psalm 8:5–6).

Job 39:13–18

In the ancient Near East, people believed the ostrich was a bird that God had not given wisdom.

Job 39:14–16

The ostrich symbolizes neglect for her young because she (Lamentations 4:3):

1. Leaves her eggs on the ground.
2. Seems to abandon her eggs when a predator comes near. She is probably trying to distract the predator from the nest.
3. Lays her eggs with other female ostrich in a shared nest, so many eggs are not her own.

Job 39:18

laughs at the horse and its rider: See 39:7, 22; 41:29.

Job 39:24

They blew the ram's horn in battle to signal the attack (Joshua 6:4–6).

Job 39:30

Where there is a dead body, you will find the eagle feeding on the remains (Ezekiel 39:17–19; Matthew 24:28; Luke 17:37).

Job 40:1–2

The ancient Greek Old Testament (Septuagint) does not include the end of God's first speech.

Job 40:3–5

Job's short and humble reply does not admit guilt, but it does admit how "insignificant" he is (40:4). Earlier, he believed he could approach God like a prince or even question him (31:37; 13:22–23).

Job 40:4

- I am insignificant (compare 42:6): Job was not asking God to forgive his sin. Like Abraham, he recognized that he was not worthy (Genesis 18:27).
- Job had asked those comforting him to cover their mouths to show shock (21:5). Here, he does so himself in reaction to his own inappropriate words.

Job 40:5

I have nothing to add: He had no more accusations against God and would not argue again.

Job 40:6–7

The LORD repeated his earlier challenge (refer to 38:1–3).

Job 40:8

Job's words had angered Elihu (10:7; 27:2; 31:35–37; 32:2; 34:5). Now, God himself challenged Job's words.

Job 40:11–12

Job could not humble proud people without God's authority (Isaiah 2:11–12, 17; James 4:6; 1 Peter 5:5–6; Malachi 4:3; Romans 16:20).

Job 40:15–24

- After listing natural animals, God described Behemoth and "Leviathan" as creatures humans cannot control (39:1–30; 40:15–24; 41:1–34). Job could not control the wild donkey or ox (39:5–12; 40:15–24). However, God created and could control them, and Job had to accept this fact (41:2).
- Here, Behemoth appears to be a natural creature:

1. It is an animal God made, just as he made Job (40:15).
2. It is not a fierce predator but eats grass like an ox (40:15).
3. It is in a poem about God's creation of the natural world, not in a myth about the world's formation. Most commentators think Behemoth is the hippopotamus, a large, grass-eating animal (40:15–19). It rests in the river among lotus plants and reeds (40:21). Like the wild ox, Behemoth is strong (40:16–18, 24; 39:11). Yet it is mostly peaceful (40:20–23).

Job 41:1

Unlike the peaceful Behemoth (Job 40:15–24), Leviathan was a threat (see also Job 3:8; Psalms 74:14; 104:26; Isaiah 27:1). Most scholars think Leviathan was like a crocodile, with its powerful jaws and tough skin twisting and turning in the water (Job 41:14; 41:15–17, 23; 41:31–32). But Leviathan is a fire-breathing dragon that wraps around the sun to cause the sun to seem covered (41:18–21; 3:8–9).

The background for Leviathan is the seven-headed sea monster symbolizing chaos in ancient Near Eastern mythology. In the Bible, this wild sea creature often represents chaos and evil, whose head the Lord crushes (Psalm 74:14; Isaiah 27:1; compare Job 9:13; 26:12; Psalm 89:9–10; Isaiah 30:7; 51:9). Later in the Bible, Satan is linked to the ancient serpent and great dragon (Genesis 3; Revelation 12:9; 20:2). Christ and his followers crush his head (Romans 16:20).

Job 42:1–6

Job understood the message of God's speeches: I know that You can do all things. Nothing is too hard for him (Genesis 18:14; Jeremiah 32:17; Matthew 19:26). Job says, No plan of Yours can be thwarted (Job 23:13; Isaiah 14:27; 46:10). Job realized how different he was from God.

Job 42:5

now my eyes have seen You: Before this, Job had not seen God (see 23:8). Now, like the prophet Isaiah, he has been in God's presence and feels overwhelmed by how holy God is (Isaiah 6:1).

Job 42:7

- Eliphaz the Temanite was the spokesperson for the friends, probably because of he was older. Eliphaz had a false claim that his advice came from visions of prophecy (4:12–16). Now God spoke to him, but not to support his message.

- Unlike his three friends, Job spoke accurately about God (compare 13:7–10). Job's direct questions were more effective in finding out the truth about God than the friends' shallow definitions of doctrine.

Job 42:8–9

- The LORD made Job the "mediator" that Job had hoped to find for himself and that Elihu wanted to be (9:33; 16:19–21; 19:25; 32:1–37:24).
- go to My servant Job: God wanted Job's friends to make peace with Job before they offered their gifts (Matthew 5:23–24).
- My servant Job will pray for you: He had also prayed for his children (1:5; compare James 5:16; 1 John 5:16).
- When the LORD accepted Job's prayer, it ironically fulfilled Eliphaz's promise (Job 22:26–30).

Job 42:10

Job's fortunes probably included his health (42:16–17). God created humans to bless them, not to do them harm (curse).

Job 42:11

- Even though God restored Job, he still needed comfort for the loss of his children. His family and former friends continued to support him, following Job's earlier practices, taking over where the three friends had stopped (4:4; 16:5; 2:11; compare 2 Corinthians 7:6).
- The money given to Job was not just charity to increase his wealth again. It was also to honor him and gain favor from an influential man (for example, Proverbs 18:16). It might also have been to ease any lack of favor (for example, Genesis 32:20; 33:10; 43:11; 1 Samuel 25:27).
- Women wore a gold ring in their nose (Genesis 24:47; Proverbs 11:22; Isaiah 3:21). Both men and women wore them on the ears (Genesis 35:4; Exodus 32:2–3; Judges 8:24).

Job 42:12

When God blessed Job, it ironically fulfilled Bildad's promise (8:7).

Job 42:14

- The names of Job's new daughters reflect his good fortune God had renewed:
- Jemimah means "dove" (see Song 2:14).
- Keziah means "cassia" or "cinnamon flower" (see Psalm 45:8).
- Keren-happuch means "horn of antimony," which is a shiny container for make-up.

Job 42:15

their father granted them an inheritance among their brothers: Daughters usually inherited only if there were no male children (Numbers 27; 36). Perhaps Job's unusual action indicated his great wealth. Only a rich man could give some wealth to the families into which his daughters would marry.

Job 42:16

- Job lived for 140 more years, which was about twice as long as a normal life (Psalm 90:10). If God gave him double what he had before (Job 42:10), Job may have already been 70 years old, making his total life 210 years. This would fit the time of the early patriarchs in the Bible (see Genesis 25:7; 35:28; 47:28; 50:26; Deuteronomy 34:7; Joshua 24:29).
- to the fourth generation: God blessed Job by letting him live long enough to see his children, grandchildren, great-grandchildren, and great-great-grandchildren grow up (Genesis 50:23; Psalm 128:6).

Job 42:17

- The patriarchs ("first fathers") Abraham and Isaac also died at an old age (Genesis 25:8; 35:29). Job too lived a long, full life. This fulfilled Eliphaz's promise (Job 5:26). His promise had its basis on God's general promise (Deuteronomy 6:2; Psalm 91:16).
- At the end of the book, the ancient Greek Old Testament (Septuagint) adds a note saying that Job will resurrect from the dead at the final resurrection. It also provides information about where and when Job and those who descended from him lived.